LIVES ACROSS A BORDER

EARN HERE. LIVE ACROSS?

Everyday choices connect places.

Singapore–Johor
Hong Kong–Shenzhen

SHOP
Shopping and leisure

CARE
Dental care

RETIRE
If travel becomes easier

EARN SPEND USE SERVICES RELATE

Jamie Ko / Researcher framing and everyday examples / Script section 1

Familiar conversations motivate the study; they do not establish how common these choices are.

WHEN LIVES SPAN A BORDER

Who gains new options? Who faces adjustment? What makes it work?

Singapore–Johor

JS-SEZ: joint economic agenda

RTS Link: separate transport project

Hong Kong–Shenzhen

A longer-established experience

GAINS & PRESSURE

Household gains can coexist with local business pressures.

PRACTICAL ACCESS

Several arrangements make cross-border choices usable.

SOCIAL TIES

Relationships connect people to help and opportunities.

Singapore MTI / EDB, 8 Jan 2025 [1.1] · LTA / Malaysia MOT, 2 Oct 2026 [1.2]

The JS-SEZ geography is in Johor. The two regional pairs offer questions, not a claim of equivalence.

REGIONAL SCALE. EVERYDAY CHOICES.

GREATER BAY AREA / 2025

11
cities

>88M
people

>RMB15T
GDP

QIANHAI / WITHIN SHENZHEN
Reported 28 July 2026

>11,000
Hong Kong firms

13,000
Hong Kong residents

LIVE WORK TRAVEL

HKSAR Government, GBA overview / development plan · Qianhai Authority, 28 Jul 2026 [2.4]

Regional scale and participation are context; these figures do not measure value created by integration.

PURCHASING POWER. EARNING OPPORTUNITY.

HOUSEHOLD OPTIONS

What can people afford?

More purchasing power
for a household

Less local demand
for a business

WORK & SUPPLIER OPPORTUNITIES

Who can take them up?

Skills and location

Professional recognition

Housing, healthcare and care

Conditions shape practical access.

A household gain and a local loss can coexist.

OECD, Economic Policy Making to Pursue Economic Welfare (2023) [2.5] · Inclusive Growth in Cities (2026) [2.1]
General evidence, not an HK–Shenzhen estimate. This study does not calculate net welfare gains.

OPPORTUNITIES NEED SUPPORT

Relationships have practical value and social value in their own right.



A wider region offers alternatives—and can create dependencies.

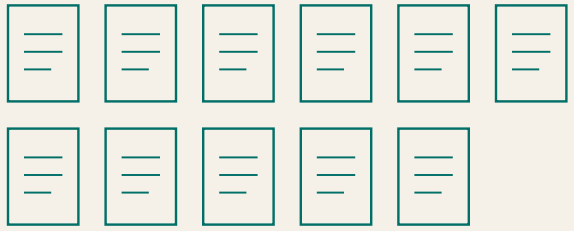
OECD (2023) [2.2] · Participant accounts [5.5] · Zeng / World Bank (2021) [2.3] · Arup / RCN (2024) [3.2]

Conceptual connections, not measured networks. Resilience is a question about adaptation, not a measured result.

ELEVEN RECORDS. TWO EXPERT DISCUSSIONS.

MIXED FIELD RECORDS

11



Informal individual and group conversations, observations and an institutional visit

EXPERT DISCUSSIONS

2



Separately logged

A different source of interpretation

COMPARED WITH Published research Official statistics Government programmes

Hong Kong–Shenzhen experience informs questions for Singapore–Johor

Research method / Eleven mixed field records; two expert discussions [3.1]

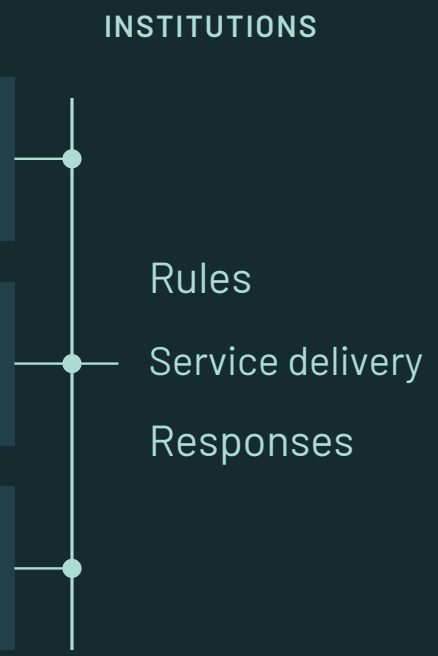
Exploratory policy analysis. These records illustrate experiences; they are not a representative sample.

THREE LENSES. INSTITUTIONS THROUGH ALL.

A **LIVELIHOODS**
Household choices · business conditions · worker adjustment

B **ACCESS**
What makes cross-border work and living feasible

C **RELATIONSHIPS**
Information and support through personal, community and professional ties



Exploratory · Hong Kong-centred · Not representative

Selected themes from Arup / Resilient Cities Network, City Resilience Framework (2024) [3.2]; study scope [3.1]
These are the study's lenses, not official framework dimensions or a measured resilience index.

A LIFE DOESN'T MOVE ALL AT ONCE.

Four overlapping arrangements

HOME · WORK · USE · TIES

		LIVE	WORK / STUDY	USE	RELATE
01	**CROSS-BORDER USER** Participant account + observation	One side	—	Shenzhen visit	—
02	**NORTHBOUND MOVER** Lower living costs, lower earnings	HK to Shenzhen	Guiding	—	Family in HK
03	**WORKER / STUDENT** Official pupil example below	One side	Other side	—	—
04	**HK-BASED, MAINLAND TIES** No regular commute established	Rents in HK	Hong Kong	—	Shenzhen

16,139 daily cross-boundary schoolchildren in 2024/25; Mainland homes are not necessarily Shenzhen.

— Not established here.

The full journey, work schedules, care and family commitments shape feasibility.

Illustrative records / expert discussion [4.1, 4.2, 4.4–4.6] · Education Bureau, 2026/27 Estimates [4.3]

Arrangements overlap. They are not population shares. Participant accounts and official pupil data are distinct evidence.

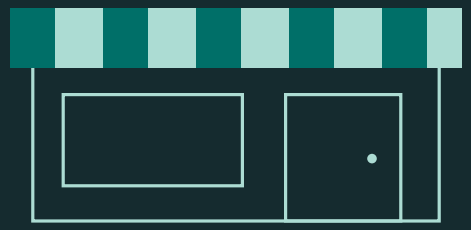
THE BORDER REACHES PEOPLE WHO STAY.

HONG KONG

ACROSS THE BORDER

Spending choices

LOCAL DEMAND



LOCAL BUSINESSES



WORKERS

Home, work, spending and ties need not move together.

Changing local demand can affect businesses and jobs.

Script section 4 / Synthesis informed by illustrative records [4.1, 4.2, 4.4]

Conceptual illustration. No measured spillover magnitude or causal effect is implied.

MOVEMENT CONTEXT

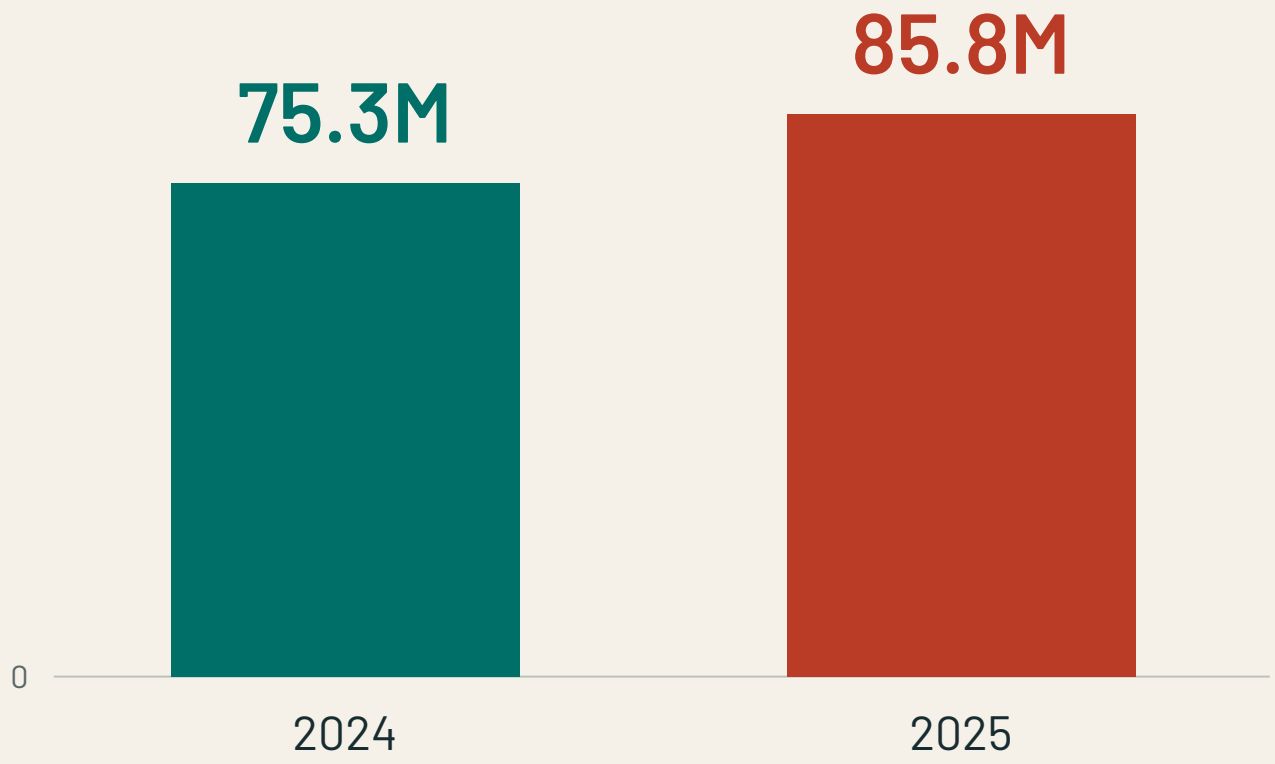
85.8 MILLION JOURNEYS

Hong Kong resident departures

One person can cross many times.

Six Shenzhen-facing checkpoints.
Repeat journeys included.

Journeys ≠ distinct people



C&SD table 650-80006 · Six Shenzhen-facing checkpoints · 2024–2025 [5.1]
Departure journeys, not unique residents, verified shopping trips or expenditure.

FINDING 1 / HOUSEHOLD CHOICES

MORE THAN A LOWER PRICE

PARTICIPANT ACCOUNTS

ACCESS TO REPAIRS

Specialist services and parts that were difficult to find locally.

PREFERRED WORK

Lower living costs made guiding more workable for one mover.

Despite lower earnings.

ESTABLISHED ALIPAYHK USERS / CUHK, 2025

MAINLAND EXPENDITURE

about half

was on services

Among users who spent there

HONG KONG EXPENDITURE

Retail was more prominent

Different places. Different baskets.

Participant accounts [4.1–4.2] · Gao, Han & Song / CUHK, 2025 [5.7]

Mainland is not Shenzhen-only. Basket differences do not estimate displaced spending or a trend.

FINDING 1 / LOCAL BUSINESSES

HOUSEHOLD GAINS. UNEVEN ADJUSTMENT.

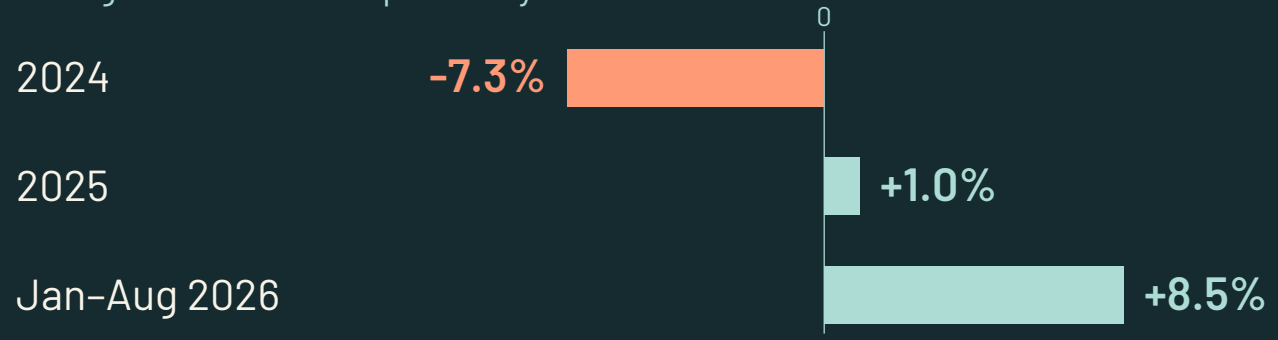
PARTICIPANT HYPOTHESIS

Workday lunch: tied to place + time

Planned outings + groceries: more movable

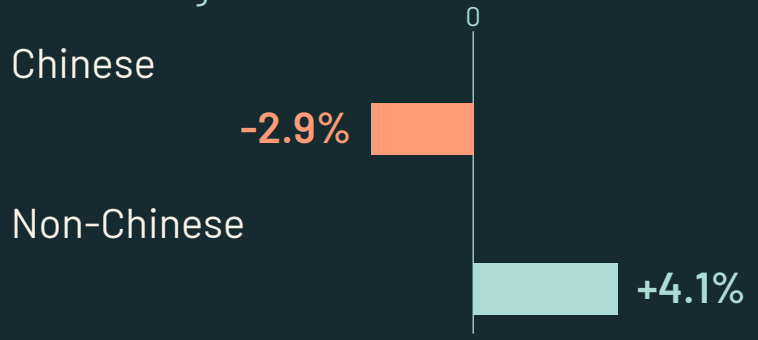
RETAIL-SALES VALUE

Change from the same period a year earlier



RESTAURANT RECEIPT VALUE

2025 · change from 2024



Mixed results do not establish a cause.

C&SD tables 620-67001, 625-68003 [5.3, 5.8] · Participant hypothesis [5.2]

Value, not volume. Jan–Aug 2026 is not a full year. These figures do not identify Shenzhen competition as the cause.

FINDING 1 / CAPACITY TO ADJUST

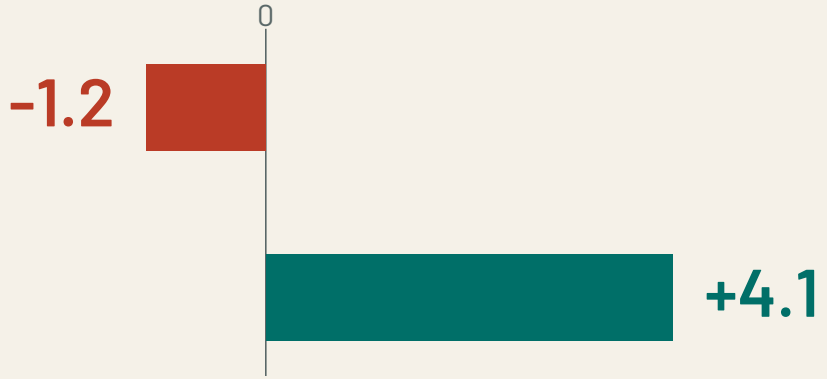
ROOM TO RESPOND DIFFERS

EXPERT INTERPRETATION

Larger chains and distinctive premium operators may have advantages in responding.

2024 FOOD-SERVICE COMPANY ACCOUNTS

Remainder after recorded costs, per HK$100 of receipts



Retail shows a less consistent pattern.

C&SD 2024 food-service table 4.1; retail table 5.1 · Author calculation [5.11] · Expert interpretation [5.9]

Aggregate size-group accounts. Remainder is not net profit, reserves or closure risk. Size does not identify chains.

FINDING 1 / WORKERS

A VACANCY IS NOT YET A WORKABLE ALTERNATIVE

EMPLOYMENT

RETAIL / APPROXIMATE CHANGE

–2,600

about –1.1%

June 2025–June 2026

FOOD + BEVERAGE

Broadly unchanged

VACANCIES

FOOD + BEVERAGE

–14%

Which alternatives fit a person's circumstances?

SKILLS | PAY | HOURS | CARE

Workable job

C&SD June 2026 employment and vacancy release, tables 1–2 [5.12]

Net sector changes do not identify individual layoffs, the people affected, or their next jobs.

FINDING 1 / TAKEAWAY

LOWER LIVING COSTS *&* EARNING OPTIONS

For people who cross, and people who remain.

MOVABLE DEMAND

Can the customer take the purchase elsewhere?

THE OFFERING

What makes a service worth choosing?

RESPONSE CAPACITY

What room does a business have to adapt?

Research synthesis · Participant accounts and C&SD sector evidence [4.1–4.2; 5.3, 5.11–5.12]

Household gains can coexist with pressure on some firms and workers; no net-welfare balance is estimated.

FINDING 2 / MAKING OPPORTUNITIES PRACTICAL

PERMISSION BECOMES USABLE WORK

A DOCUMENTED PROFESSIONAL ROUTE

ELIGIBLE → **REGISTERED** → **CONTRACTED**

Hong Kong professionals

Under GBA arrangements

Qianhai school + bridge work

Architectural + engineering firms

Other people may need other arrangements.

HOUSING	SCHOOLING	CARE
Depends on the person		

Development Bureau registration arrangements · CMAB 2025/26 Estimates, pp.114–115 [5.13]

Specific eligible professions and contracts; this does not quantify net jobs or productivity gains.

FINDING 2 / PRACTICAL ARRANGEMENTS

CONNECTED CARE

Several arrangements around one person's needs

One documented example



Records and return referrals connect parts of care.

FOLLOW-UP PILOT / HKU–SHENZHEN

>5,900 eligible HA patients

>25,000 attendances

By January 2026

Includes obstetrics + paediatrics

CROSS-BOUNDARY HEALTH RECORD

>23,000 users

Separate feature · by end-May 2026

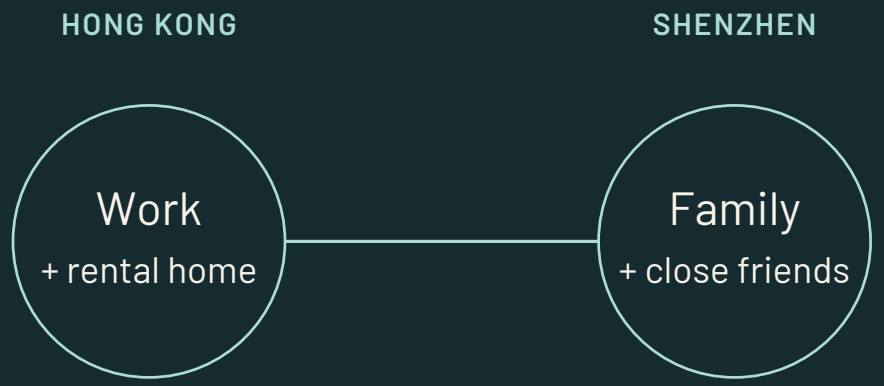
HKSAR Government replies, 25 February and 17 June 2026 [5.14, 5.6]

Distinct, potentially overlapping measures. Defined schemes, not universal coverage or evidence of clinical outcomes.

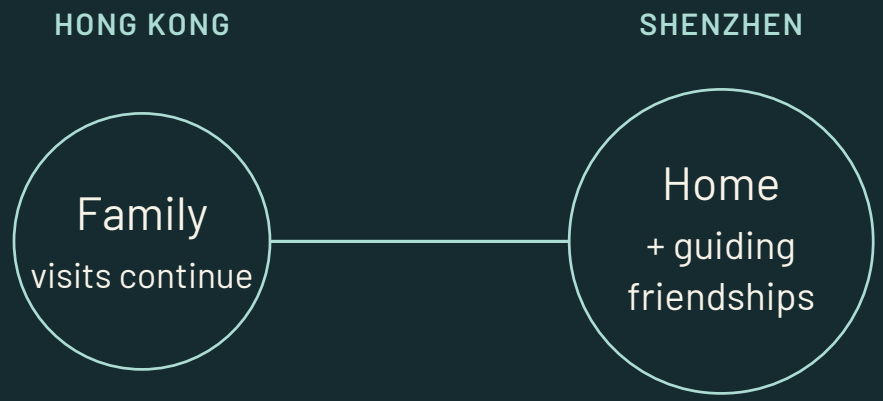
FINDING 3 / RELATIONSHIPS

MOVING HOME NEED NOT MOVE EVERY TIE.

Hong Kong–based resident



Northbound mover



Family, community and work ties can sit in different places.

Two participant accounts · Unpublished qualitative records [5.5]

Illustrative relationship diagrams, not measured networks or commute routes. These accounts do not establish prevalence.

FINDING 3 / HELP BECOMES USABLE

A LEAD STILL NEEDS A ROUTE INTO WORK

ONE MOVER'S ACCOUNT

FRIENDS' LEAD
A guiding-related opportunity

HIRING RELUCTANCE
Reported age-related barrier

SOMEONE STEPPED IN
Help from within the organisation

Other routes into local circles

SPORTS

INTEREST GROUPS

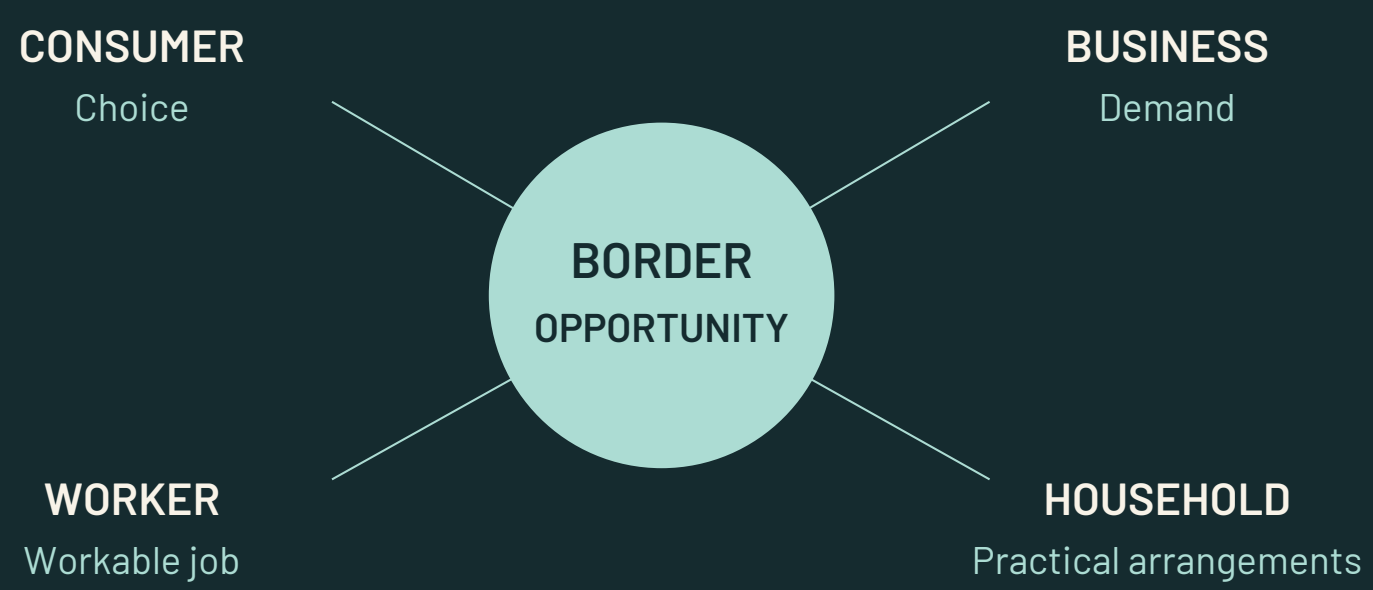
MANDARIN

One participant account · Unpublished qualitative records [5.5]

Employment sequence not independently verified. The accounts do not identify which groups lack support.

THREE FINDINGS / ONE POLICY QUESTION

SAME OPPORTUNITY. DIFFERENT IMPLICATIONS.



What works?

What needs adjustment?

Which response fits the evidence?

Research synthesis · Script Section 5 [5.3, 5.5, 5.12–5.14]

These are overlapping positions, not population segments or a ranking of who is most affected.

SUPPORT FOLLOWS DEMONSTRATED NEED.

DIFFERENT FINDINGS WARRANT DIFFERENT RESPONSES

Business + workers
Adjustment

Particular users
Practical arrangements

Finding existing help
Suitable services and groups

BUSINESS ADJUSTMENT · PROPOSED ASSESSMENT

Customer choices can move → **Actual pressure?** → **What constrains the response?** → **Proportionate action**

EXPOSURE · ASSESS · UNDERSTAND · RESPOND

Exposure alone does not establish a need for additional public support.

Script section 6 · Targeting proposal informed by section 5 evidence [5.2, 5.3, 5.11]

A proposed assessment, not an evaluated targeting rule. Build on institutions already in place.

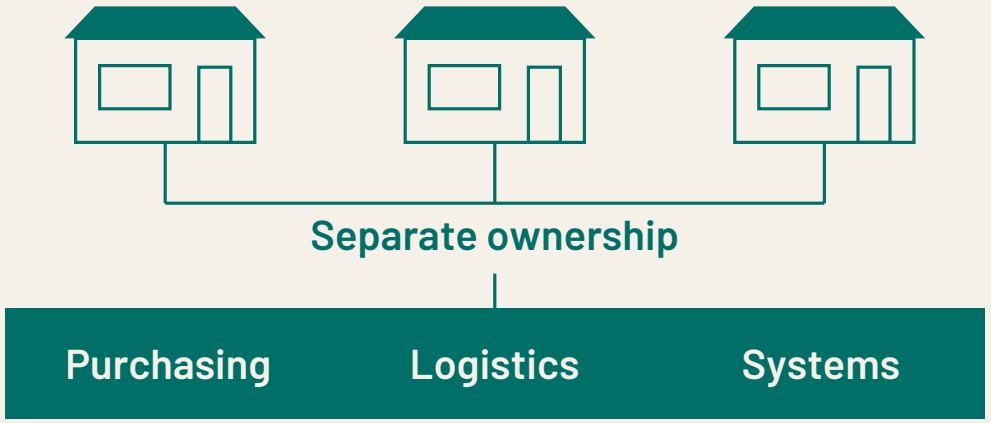
SHARE CAPACITY. FIND VIABLE DEMAND.

START WITH EXISTING HELP

Advice
Promotion
New markets

Hong Kong provision already offers a starting point.

CGC JAPAN · SHARED CAPACITY



An operating model, not a measured survival effect.

ASSESS VIABLE OPTIONS

Reposition

Product mix, customers or operating model.

Change or exit

Advisory help when no viable way forward emerges.

Solve an actual constraint. Check the demand, cost and safeguards.

Script section 6 · SME One / BUD / GoGBA; HKTB; CGC Japan; Competition Commission [6.1, 6.4, 6.9]

Collaboration and repositioning are options to assess. Shared buying requires competition safeguards.

CONNECT TRAINING TO A REALISTIC JOB.

HONG KONG · CONNECT WORKERS EARLY THROUGH EXISTING SERVICES

When firms plan staffing changes, retraining and employment services are a starting point.

SINGAPORE · PLACE-AND-TRAIN CAREER CONVERSION PROGRAMME

Hiring + Training + Salary support

Published evaluation

Estimated gains in wages and employment retention

versus comparison groups

Non-randomised; mainly PMETs

ASSESS JOB QUALITY ALONGSIDE PLACEMENT

PAY | HOURS | SUSTAINED WORK | PLACEMENT

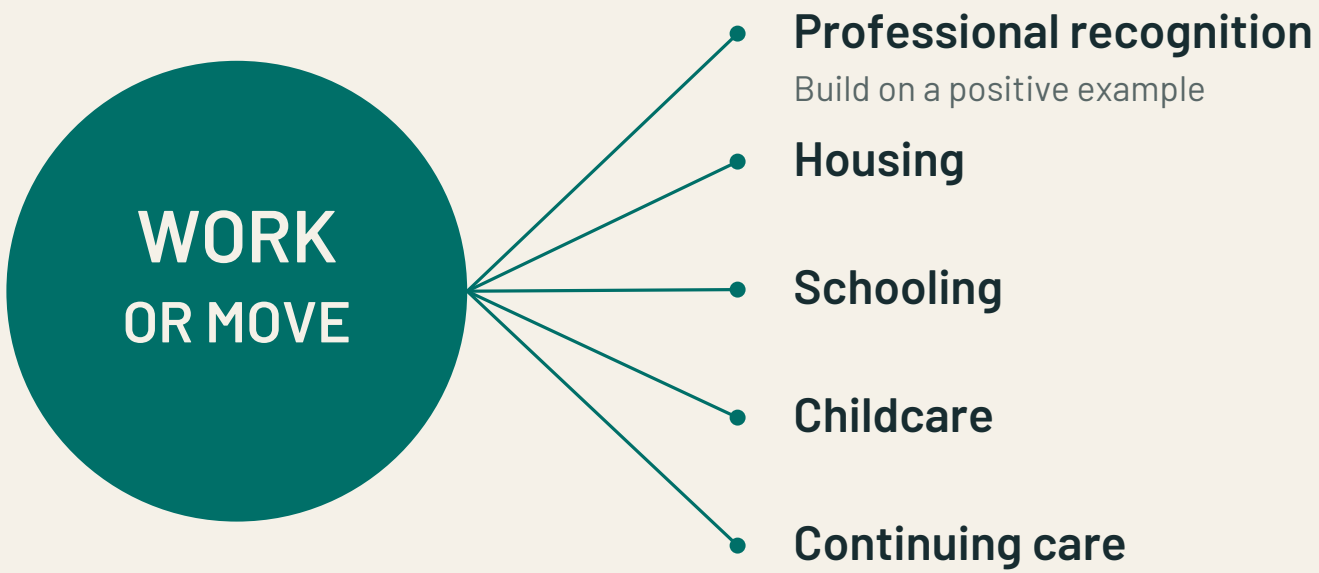
The Singapore estimate does not predict results for Hong Kong retail workers.

Script section 6 · Hong Kong retraining / employment services; Singapore CCP evaluation, 14 Feb 2025 [5.16, 6.5, 6.10]

Non-randomised; mainly PMETs; fewer than three months of placement-company employment records excluded.

START WITH THE WORK OR MOVE.

Select the arrangements on which that opportunity depends.



CARE · ONE DOCUMENTED EXAMPLE

Providers and payment-scheme administrators can clarify:

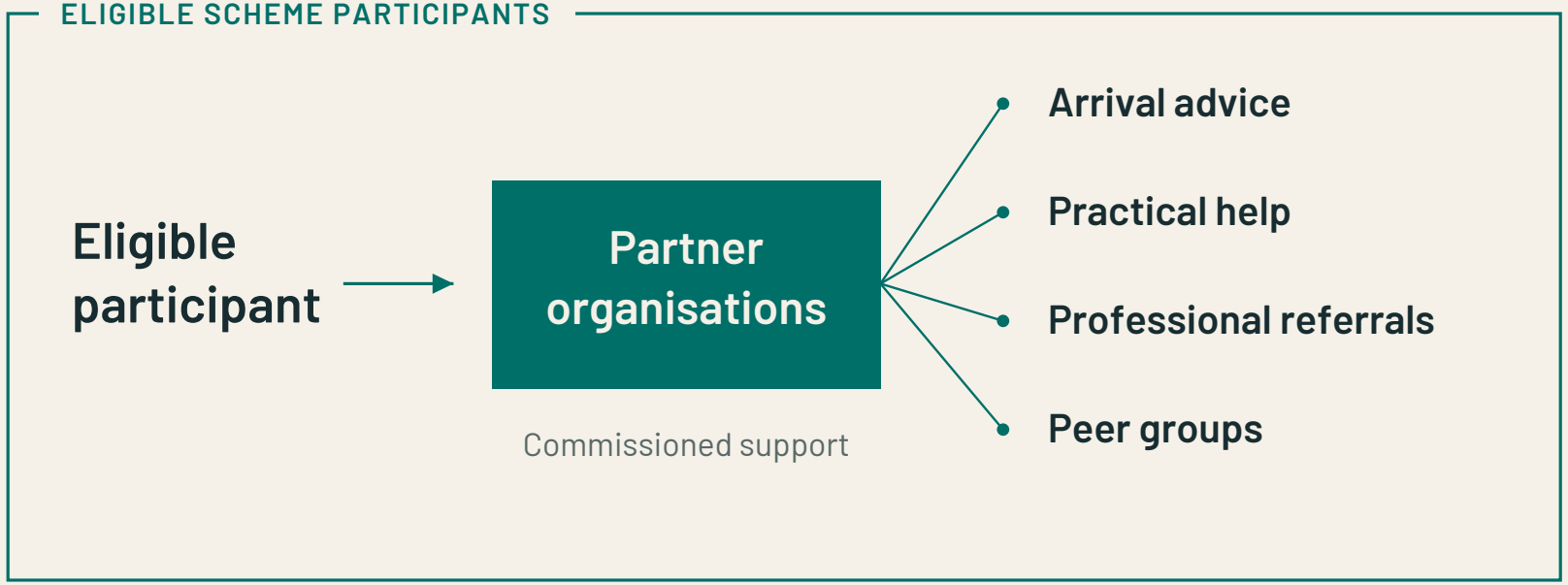
- **Coverage**
- **Payment**
- **Records**
- **Follow-up**

Address a specific gap if one emerges.

Another household may put housing or childcare first.

PRACTICAL ADVICE. REFERRALS. PEER CONTACTS.

HONG KONG · GBA YOUTH EMPLOYMENT SCHEME



SELECTIVE OUTREACH

Find suitable existing help.

Employers and community organisations can help people reach services and groups.

Prioritise demonstrated needs that current channels miss.

Script section 6 · Hong Kong Labour Department, Mainland support services [6.12]

Provision for eligible participants, not measured outcomes, universal coverage or proof others lack help.

FOLLOW OUTCOMES. BUILD ON EXISTING EVIDENCE.

PROPOSAL · FOR RESPONSIBLE AGENCIES AND PROVIDERS

EXISTING RECORDS

Statistics + programme records

Start with evidence already collected.

→

USEFUL OUTCOMES

Pay + sustained work
Contracts secured
Referrals completed
Household benefits

→

SELECTIVE EVALUATION

Stronger evaluation where substantial resources are involved

SINGAPORE–JOHOR

Reference point before RTS opens

HONG KONG–SHENZHEN

Particular changes and services

Public support should address demonstrated needs, with benefits that justify its cost.

Script section 6 · Measurement proposal [6.13]; existing practices: MOM re-entry tracking / Skills4Johor follow-up

Proposed follow-up, not an implemented index. Before/after improvement alone is not causal evidence.

A DIFFERENT BORDER. TWO POSSIBLE SHIFTS.

A SELECTIVE APPLICATION OF THE FINDINGS

Singapore

RTS

A separate travel link

Johor

JS-SEZ
Designated area within Johor

01 **SPENDING**

02 **LIVES**

Script §7 / JS-SEZ factsheet [7.1]; RTS timing [1.2, 7.7]

Different institutions and legal arrangements. Diagram is conceptual, not a boundary map.

TWO DIRECTIONS. ONE ADJUSTMENT QUESTION.

FORECAST ADDITIONAL ANNUAL CONSUMER SPENDING

Singapore consumers → Johor Bahru

S$1.05bn — Singapore to Johor Bahru

Singapore ← Johor Bahru consumers

S$756m — Johor Bahru to Singapore

About S$290m net incremental outflow — not lost GDP

EXPOSURE: groceries / drugstores / dining / beauty

Script §7 / SBF, RAS and SRA commissioned RTS study, July 2026 [7.5]

Forecasts, not realised effects or JS-SEZ impacts. Both arrows share one monetary scale.

PREPARE. COMPARE. ADJUST.

01 **PRIORITISE**

Categories and customer needs

02 **ENGAGE**

Existing business channels

03 **CONNECT**

Workers and practical support

04 **COMPARE**

Actual flows with forecasts

EnterpriseSG / trade associations / heartland-business channels

Script §7 / Existing EnterpriseSG, retail and food-sector support [7.4, 7.9]

Proposed focus within existing provision. Eligibility varies; these are not RTS-specific programmes.

IF

travel became easier…

CONDITIONAL INTEREST / 2024 SURVEY

Around 1 in 3

Singapore respondents could envisage buying a JB home and retiring there.

Healthcare

Family responsibilities

Local support

Practical questions. Not observed relocation.

Script §7 / Blackbox Research, SensingSG, February 2024 [7.6]

Respondents, not one-third of all Singaporeans. The condition is part of the finding.

HELP BEFORE AND AFTER A MOVE.

PARTICULAR USERS / APPROPRIATE EXISTING PROVIDERS

BEFORE

Understand coverage, records and the arrangements a move depends on.

AFTER

Find practical advice, follow-up, useful referrals and peer contacts.

SINGAPORE / SCHEME REVIEW

Limited overseas MediSave arrangements; review is not an expanded entitlement.

GBA / ELIGIBLE PARTICIPANTS

Existing youth-employment support brings advice, referrals and peer contacts together.

Script §7 / Singapore MOH and GBA Youth Employment Scheme [7.7, 7.10]

Examples prompt questions; entitlements do not transfer automatically across a sovereign border.

WHOSE EXPERIENCE WILL GUIDE THE RESPONSE?

JOHOR RESIDENTS ALONGSIDE INCOMING HOUSEHOLDS

Opportunities

Local firms, suppliers and workers

Possible pressures

Housing and relevant services

Existing organisations

Handle business and service issues within their responsibilities.

Bilateral action when needed

Use the Johor–Singapore Cooperation Ministerial Committee where both governments must act.

Script §7 / Johor–Singapore Cooperation Ministerial Committee [7.3]

Track actual experience. No measured housing effect or automatic repetition of Hong Kong is claimed.

THREE FINDINGS. DIFFERENT RESPONSES.

01	GAINS + PRESSURE	→	Target business and worker adjustment
02	CONNECTED ACCESS	→	Start with particular users
03	DISTRIBUTED TIES	→	Make existing help easier to reach

Script §8 / Synthesis of exploratory research

Follow demonstrated problems and build on existing institutions. Responses have different evidence bases.

WHEN LIVES SPAN A BORDER

CHEAPER LIVING. STRONGER EARNING OPPORTUNITIES.

Can they endure as needs change?

Jamie Ko AsiaGlobal Fellows / 2026

Explore the research

Research and presentation: Jamie Ko / Visual support: Bob

Exploratory findings and practical questions; no citywide resilience score or net-welfare estimate.